

Saint John Chrysostom
Homilies on David and Saul

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HOMILY I.

Of David and Saul, and of tolerance, and that it is necessary to spare enemies, and not to speak ill of those who are absent.

1. Whenever a prolonged and severe swelling has adhered to the body, a long time, much labor, and considerable wisdom are needed in applying remedies, so that the accumulated swelling may be dissolved without danger to life. The same is true of the soul. For whenever someone wishes to uproot a disease that has already taken root in the soul and has been fixed for a long time, a single or two-day admonition is not enough for correction; rather, this matter must be treated frequently over many days. Only then are we to carry out this office of preacher, not for ambition and pleasure, but for fruit and utility. Therefore, as we did regarding oaths, having discussed the same subject with you for many days, let us now do the same about anger, and pursue continuous exhortation about it for our part, as men. For this seems to me to be the best way of teaching, if we do not cease consulting about any matter before we see that the admonition has reached its effect. For he who speaks today of almsgiving, tomorrow of prayer, the next day of humanity, and then again of modesty of mind, will not be able to accomplish any of these things properly in the minds of his hearers, always jumping from this to that, and again from that to another. But it is necessary that he who wishes his speech to achieve the intended fruit in the minds of his hearers should not cease from admonishing and advising them about the same things, nor should he jump to something else before he has seen the previous admonition well fixed and rooted in them. The same is what schoolmasters are wont to do: they do not bring the children to the syllables until they have seen the knowledge of the elements properly confirmed in them. Recently, therefore, by relating to you the parable of the hundred denarii and the ten thousand talents, we showed how great an evil it is

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to remember injuries. For he whom ten thousand talents had not destroyed, they drowned in the destruction of a hundred denarii, and they revoked the pardon granted for debts, and wasted the remission of the money due (Matthew 18:23–35), and he who had been freed from crimes, they dragged him back to judgment, and from there they threw him into prison, and finally delivered him over to immortal punishment. But today we will attempt to speak of a different subject. For it was necessary, if what was right were to be done, to provide examples of this pre-eminent philosophy, giving from himself examples of humanity and meekness, and thus at the same time to teach it in words and instruct them in it by deeds. But since we are long absent from this virtue, we will use a certain number of saints brought into the midst, and subject to your eyes, to apply a somewhat clear and powerful exhortation, so that we may urge both you and ourselves, as it were, to the emulation of a certain archetype.

Who then is to be brought forward in the midst of the world to speak of humanity? Who else but he who has deserved to be praised by heavenly testimony, and for this very reason is to be most highly regarded? I have found, he says, David the son of Jesse, a man after my own heart (1 Samuel 13:14; Acts 13:22). Moreover, after God has spoken, there is no occasion left to contradict. For his judgment is uncorrupted, because God does not judge with grace, nor does he judge by hatred, but by the mere virtue of the mind he gives suffrage. But we have not brought forward this man in the midst of the world only because he was praised by God's suffrage, but also because he is one of those who were brought up under the old law. If, by grace, there should have been someone pure from anger, forgiving the offenses of enemies, and sparing those who had offended him, it is certainly nothing surprising, especially after the death of Christ, after he had so mercifully forgiven us all our sins, after so many precepts full of

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evangelical philosophy. But in the Old Testament, when the law permitted an eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth (Exodus 21:24), and he who had allowed the penalty of retaliation to be avenged, there should have been someone who had crossed the boundaries of the precepts, and had arrived at apostolic philosophy, who would not have astonished his hearers? Whom, if we do not imitate, would we not be deprived of all forgiveness and all excuse? But that you may know his virtue more accurately, grant me to repeat the prayer a little more deeply, and to mention the benefits which that blessed man bestowed on Saul. For it is not surprising that an enemy should not be avenged who has simply injured him; but he who has attempted to kill a man who has been favored by him with many benefits, but who has done him good for his good deeds, once and again, nay, frequently, after he had fallen into his hands, so that it was now lawful to kill, not only did he let him go, but also rescued him from the snares of others; especially since he knew that he would afterwards attempt the same thing: what else did he do that can be adjoined to the highest philosophy?

2. But bear with me as I recount briefly what benefits David bestowed on Saul, when and how. When at one time the Jews were oppressed by a most difficult war, so that all were terrified with fear, and no one dared to raise his head, but the city was in extreme despair, each one having death before his eyes, and all daily expecting destruction, so that they might lead a life more miserable than those who live in the most terrible prison, this man, coming from the sheep to the army, although he could not learn the art of war through age, and was unaccustomed to military labors, himself took the war upon himself for all, and conducted the matter successfully, beyond what anyone had hoped. Although even if the result had been lacking in virtue, yet he was to be crowned for his readiness of mind and excellent purpose

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alone. Now if any of the soldiers, being of age, had designed this deed, it would have been nothing surprising, namely, that it was required by military law. But this one, who saw no necessity driving him here, and had many discouraging him: for both his brother rebuked him, and the king, perceiving that he was not yet mature in age, and unfit to bear dangers, restrained him, and ordered him to remain, saying: You cannot go, for you are a boy; but he is a man of war from his youth (1 Samuel 17:33). Yet when no occasion provoked him, of his own accord and of himself inflamed with divine zeal, and love of his country, just as if he saw sheep more truly than men, and as if he were going to attack dogs rather than so numerous an army of men, he ran so fearlessly towards the barbarians: and at that time he declared such great solicitude for the king, that even before the battle and victory he raised him up prostrate on his face. For he not only helped him with his deeds, but also with his words, encouraging him to be of good cheer, and persuading him, so that he might conceive good hopes of the outcome, he effected thus speaking: Let not the heart of my lord be grieved in him, for your servant will go and fight with this stranger (1 Samuel 17:52). I ask, does this seem a small thing, compelled by no necessity, to betray his own life, and to rush into the midst of the enemy for the benefit of those from whom he had received no benefits? Was it not fitting, after such a deed, to call him, with an ornate title inscribed on the pillars of the lord, and the public savior of the city, who preserved both the glory of the kingdom and the foundations of cities, and all his life by the helping grace of God? What other benefit could be greater than this? For he did not contribute this act to glory or power, but to his own life itself, and he escaped from the very gates of death. Therefore, if you consider human support, he then lived and maintained his principality by his benefit. And afterwards, what favor did he bestow upon him? For if anyone were to weigh the greatness of the deeds, even if the king had placed the crown taken from his own

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head on David's head, he would never have returned an equal favor, but he should have received a greater favor. For here he gave him his life and the kingdom, but he was only going to give up the kingdom to him. However, let us consider the favor returned for good deeds. What was that? Moreover, from that day on David was suspected, and he feared him. Why and for what reason? For the reason for suspicion must also be mentioned. For not everything someone says is just. For towards him who laid down his life and gave his life, what could be a just cause for suspicion? But let us examine the cause of enmity itself, so that you may learn something, that neither victory itself is inferior: and that David is honorable because of those very things, because of which suspicion has come afterwards, there is a desire for ambushes. What then was the reason for suspicion? After he had taken the head of that barbarian, and returned carrying the spoils: "The women came out," he says, "singing and saying, 'Saul has slain his thousands, and David his ten thousands.'" And Saul was angry, and he suspected David from that day forward (1 Samuel 18:6–9). For whose sake, I pray you? Even if these things had been said undeservedly, it was not necessary to bear a hostile mind towards David. But since from his deeds he had ascertained his benevolence towards him, since he, without any coercion or compulsion, had thus voluntarily undergone discrimination, it was not necessary to suspect anything evil of him from thenceforth. Now, however, praises were rightly uttered; and if it is right to speak the truth, the favors attributed to Saul were rather than to David; but he should have been satisfied that they had given him a thousand. Why then was he indignant that David was given ten thousand? For if the king had thought even a little about ending the war, it would have been rightly said, Saul in his thousands, David in his ten thousands. But if he himself, fearful and trembling, went home, expecting death every day, and yet committed a terrible crime: was it not absurd for him, who had done nothing to ward off dangers, to be

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indignant because he had not received more praise? For if he was to be indignant, it was rather fitting for David to be indignant, because, since he had done it all alone, he had another to share in the praise.

3. But I say nothing of these: I would say this: that we may grant that the women did not correct him, and that they were liable to be mocked and worthy of accusation, what is this to David? For he had not composed the song himself, nor had he urged them to say what they said, nor had he adorned that manner of praise. Therefore, even if it were right to be indignant, it was right to be indignant at the women, not at a citizen who had deserved well and was worthy of endless crowns. But Saul, omitting them, was angry with David. Now if that blessed man, deprived of that praise, had envied the one who was mighty in success, and had been contemptuous of him, and had despised his authority, perhaps there would have been some cause for envy. But if he had become more humane and modest, if he had kept himself in the order of subjects, what was finally a just cause for grief? For when he who is affected by honor is exalted against him by whom he was advanced, and does not cease to despise and abuse honor, he has some excuse for his pain. But where does he persist in dishonoring him, or rather does he obey him, and yield in all things, whom he can afterwards have as a pretext for envy? David is not brought up because of his prosperous success.

Therefore, even if nothing else had been done brilliantly, he was still more to be loved for this very reason, because, when he had found such an opportunity to seize the kingdom, he persisted in his modesty. For it was not only the things that had gone before, but also those that followed, which were much more glorious than those before, that lifted his spirits. What then? David, he says, was prudent in all his ways, and the Lord Almighty was with him, and all Israel and Judah loved David, because he went in and out before the people. And Michal the daughter

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of Saul, and all Israel loved him. He was wiser than all the servants of Saul; and his name was greatly honored (1 Samuel 18:14, 16, 20, 30). And Jonathan the son of Saul loved David greatly (1 Samuel 18:2). However, since he had the entire people and the king's family on his side, since he was victorious everywhere in wars, and was never frustrated by success, and since he received such favor for the things he had done well, he did not raise his neck, nor did he desire the kingdom, nor did he avenge his enemy, but persevered in doing good, and in successfully waging wars for the king. Who is the cruel and inhuman man whom these things would not persuade to lay down his enmity and cast off his envy? But he did not yield to any of these things; but blind to all this, and given to envy, he tried to remove him from the midst: and what, I pray you, was he doing? (for that is greater and more astonishing,) playing the harp, and calming his own madness. David, he says, played with his hand daily: and a spear was in Saul's hand: and Saul took up a spear, and said, I will thrust it into David; and he fastened it to the wall: and David turned aside from his presence twice (1 Samuel 18:11). Can anything be added to this malice? Perhaps those which followed afterwards. He who had lately driven away the enemies, by whom the city had been restored to him, all sacrificing victims for the victory: Saul attempted to kill the benefactor and preserver, and the author of their good things, while he was singing: and not even the memory of the benefits restrained him, who was furious and delirious, but once and twice they twisted him with these, then with these also other greater things.

5. But none of these things did that just man weigh with himself, considering only this one thing, how he might redeem the crown of tolerance, and practice a certain new and admirable philosophy. For it was not at all surprising if, when he was alone and without companions, he had spared him by whom he had been injured, and

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now he did the same to others present. For the presence of those soldiers was a double obstacle to philosophy. It often happens to us ourselves, that when we have ceased to remit vengeance and to pardon the charges, then, when we see some irritating and inciting us, we change our mind and obey their words. But this did not happen to this blessed man; even after their advice and exhortation, he persevered in his purpose of mind. But this is not the only thing worthy of admiration, that he was not moved from his purpose by the admonition of others, and that he did not fear them, but that he accomplished it, so that they also assumed the same moderation of mind. It is indeed a great thing if one can control one's desires; but it is much greater to be able to persuade others to have the same mind: others, I say, who are neither modest nor temperate men, but soldiers, who had already been driven to despair by many difficulties, from which they desired a little respite, not unaware that not only the entire solution of evils lay in the killing of the enemy; and not only the solution of evils, but also the acquisition of many goods, since nothing prevented the kingdom from passing immediately to David after he was murdered. However, since there were so many things that irritated the soldiers, that noble man was so powerful that he was superior to all of them, and persuaded them to spare their enemies.

It is worth the effort, indeed, to listen to the counsel of the soldiers themselves, because the cunning of their counsel shows the firm and solid mind of a just man. For they did not speak thus: Behold he who has plotted many evils against you, who has desired your death, who has surrounded us with incurable difficulties: but when they saw that David neglected all these things, and did not have much reason for the things committed against him, they allege to him a divine author, saying, God delivered him up, that, namely, he might fear the judgment that had proceeded from God, and go the more readily to the murder.

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Will you, they say, avenge your own wrong? You serve and minister to God; you confirm his judgment. But the more they said these things, the more he spared the enemy, for he understood that God had delivered him up for this purpose, that he might supply himself with greater occasions of proving his virtue. Therefore you also, if ever your enemy falls into your hands, beware of thinking that you have been given an opportunity to avenge him, but rather to preserve the enemy. And then we must most spare our enemies when they have perhaps come into our power. But here perhaps someone would have said, And what great or wonderful thing do you have in your power to spare? For many, both kings and viceroys, having risen to the throne, judged themselves unworthy of the punishments they had received at the height of their kingdom from those by whom they had once been offended: the very power of the throne brought about a cause of reconciliation. But in this case, you cannot say anything of the kind. For David, having neither been raised to the principality, nor having obtained the kingdom, and having the kingdom in his hands, did not spare him so that no one could be caused to have been relieved of his anger by the greatness of his kingdom. But since he knew that he would be saved, and would himself be thrown into graver dangers, he did not kill him for that very reason. Let us not compare him with them. For since they have a certain and safe pledge of future security, they deserve to spare him; but this man, though he knew that he was sending the enemy to his own destruction, and giving safety to his enemy, yet he did not kill him, and that although he had many driving forces to that murder. For the solitude of the king, deprived of his help, the exhortation of the sword, the memory of the past, the fear of the future; the conviction that if he had killed the enemy, he could not be condemned for bloodshed, and that after the law had been carried out, he seemed to surpass it in meekness; these and many other things urged and compelled him to stab him with the sword. But he yielded to

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none of these, but persisted like an invincible diamond, preserving the untarnished law of philosophy. But you must not suppose that he felt any of those feelings which it was fitting that he should have felt, but what happened was not philosophy, but stupor: consider how vehemently exasperated he controlled himself. Indeed, waves of anger had swelled in his mind, and many a storm of thoughts had been stirred up, but that the fear of God had restrained that storm, and had subdued his spirits, may be seen from what happened. He arose, he says, and secretly took the hem of Saul's cloak. Do you see how great a storm of anger had arisen? But he went no further, nor did he cause shipwreck, because the governor, immediately sensing the danger, namely pious reason, turned the storm into calmness. For, he says, it struck David's heart, and like a horse leaping and raging, it recalled his anger (1 Samuel 24:4–6).

6. The souls of the saints are of this kind: before they fall, they rise again; before they reach sin, they are restrained, because they are sober, and always watchful. And yet how great was the distance between the body and the garment? Yet he restrained himself, lest he should go further: and moreover for this very reason he severely condemned himself. For, he says, his heart smote him, because he had taken away the hem of his cloak, and said to the men: Far be it from the Lord (1 Samuel 24:6). What is that, Far be it from the Lord? he says, be it to me, if I had willed this: may God never permit me to do this, nor permit me to come to such a state. Since he saw that this philosophy almost surpassed human nature, and that he needed heavenly help, and that he had almost gone to murder, he prays that the Lord would keep his hand undefiled. What could be milder to this mind? Shall we call this man a man who in human nature lived an angelic life? But the divine laws will not allow that. For who, I pray you, would easily ask such a thing from God? What did I say, such a

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thing? Who would endure not to pray against him who had been a troublemaker? For most mortals are so taken with savagery that, when they are so weak that they are unable to do any harm to the one by whom they have been harassed, they call upon God for vengeance, that he may give them the power to harm those who have brought evil upon them. But here, praying as if diametrically opposed to all of them, he begs that he not permit him to lay hands on him, speaking in this manner: Let not this happen to me from the Lord, that I should lay my hand on him (1 Samuel 24:6): just as he speaks of a son and of an offspring, so he speaks of an enemy.

He did not only spare Saul, but also prepared an excuse for him. See indeed how prudently and wisely. For when, examining the life of Saul, he had found nothing good, so that he could say, He was not injured by him, nor suffered any inconvenience (for the soldiers who were present were about to complain about this, and had known the king's wickedness by experience), he went around on the other side, trying to find a probable excuse. When he could not do this, neither from his life nor from his deeds, he took refuge in his dignity, saying: Because he is the Lord's anointed (1 Samuel 24:6). What do you say, they say? That he is a criminal, that he is covered with crimes, and filled with innumerable vices, and thinks the worst of us? But he is a king, but a prince, and he has assumed a principality over us. And yet he did not say, he is a king, but, he is the Lord's anointed, not from human honor, but from the honorable testimony received from the heavenly judgment. Do you despise, he says, your fellow servant? Reverence for the Lord. Do you despise the chosen one? Fear him who has chosen. For if we fear and awe these ordinary prefects appointed by the Emperor, even if they are wicked, if they are thieves, if they are robbers, if they are unjust, if they are anything else, we fear and awe them, not because we despise them for their wickedness, but because

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we revere the dignity of him by whom they were chosen: much more is it fitting to do so towards those whom God has chosen. God has not yet, he says, deprived him of his principality; he has not yet deprived him of his kingship. Therefore let us not invert the order, nor fight with God, fulfilling by our deeds that apostolic saying: For whoever resists the power resists the ordinance of God; and whoever resists will receive damnation to himself (Romans 13:2). He not only called him Christ, that is, anointed king; but he also called him his lord. It is not mediocre philosophy to call an enemy of honor and obedience by the terms of honor. And again, how great this is, someone can see from what happens to others. Most people do not even bear to call their enemies by their bare and simple names, but call them by other hateful terms: impious, insane, possessed, mad, pestilent: they combine many other things, and designate the enemy with these characteristics. I will show that this is true, by an example not sought from afar, but taken from the nearest, namely from this same Saul, who, because of his vehement hatred, could not bear to call this just man by his own name, but when a certain feast was being celebrated, he inquired, saying, Where is the son of Jesse (1 Samuel 20:27)? But he called him thus partly out of hatred of his own name, partly out of recognition of the meanness of his father, hoping that by this agreement the reputation of the just would be defiled, not understanding that a man is usually made noble and illustrious, not by the renown of his ancestors, but by the virtue of his mind. But blessed David did not do the same. For he did not call him by his father's surname, although he too was very humble and despised; nor did he designate him by a bare and simple name, but by a title of dignity and principality. So pure was his mind from all malevolence. Therefore, you too, my dearest, imitating him, learn first of all never to call your enemy by hateful names, but rather by honorable ones. For if the mouth has accustomed itself to call him who has injured you by names of honor and service, the mind, hearing this,

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will not shrink from returning to favor with him, having been taught by the tongue. For the very words will be the best remedy for the ulcer swelling in the heart.

7. I have spoken these things now, not only that we may praise David, but that we may also emulate him. Therefore let each one picture this story in his own heart, constantly drawing in his mind with contemplation as with a hand that twofold cave, Saul himself sleeping inside, and bound by sleep as with a chain, subject to him whom he had most grievously wounded by the right hand; David looming over him as he slept, the soldiers present, and exhorting him to the slaughter; the blessed one philosophizing, that is, restraining his own and their anger, and excusing him who had sinned so much. Let us not only picture these things in our minds, but let us also speak them constantly in our meetings: let us frequently renew these narratives with our wives, these with our children. For whether you wish to speak of the king, behold the king; whether of the soldiers, or of family affairs, or of public and civil affairs, you will see in the Scriptures a great abundance of all these. Such commemorations bring the greatest benefit. For it is impossible, I say, impossible, for a mind engaged in such stories to be overcome by desires. Therefore, lest we waste time uselessly, nor waste our lives in vain in foolish and superfluous trifles, let us learn the deeds of brave men, and discuss them constantly. But if anyone in the assembly wishes to speak either about spectacles, or about the running of horses, or about things that have nothing to do with you, make him recall them from that matter, and introduce them into such a narrative, by which at the same time, with purified souls and pleasure that is free from danger, delighted, and finally made gentle and placable towards all those who have done us wrong, we may depart from this life, having no enemy in the world to come, and may obtain eternal goods, through the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom be

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glory forever. Amen.

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That it is a great good, not only to exercise virtue, but also to praise it; and that David erected a more magnificent trophy by sparing Saul than by prostrating Goliath; and that in doing this he benefited himself more than Saul; and of his apology to Saul.

1. It is profitable to praise those endowed with virtue. --You indeed recently praised David for his endurance of evils; I, on the other hand, admired your benevolence and affection for David. For one ought not only to draw near and emulate virtue, but also to extol with praise those who embrace virtue and proclaim them admirable—this brings us fruit that is no ordinary thing. Just as, on the contrary, not only to emulate wickedness, but also to praise those who live in it, prepares for us no mean punishment. And if it is permissible to say something new and admirable, a heavier punishment awaits them than those who live badly. Paul, declaring this, after he had enumerated every kind of wickedness and accused all who trample upon the laws of God, adds concerning them: "Who, knowing the justice of God, that they which commit such things are worthy of death, not only do them, but also approve them that commit them: therefore art thou inexcusable, O man" (Romans 1:32; Romans 2:1). You see him speaking in such a way as to show that this is more grievous than that. For to praise offenders, which pertains to punishment, is far more than to offend; and rightly so, because this slander proceeds from a mind that is utterly corrupt and suffering from an incurable disease. For he who, while sinning, condemns his sin, may at some time, in the course of time, return to himself; but he who praises wickedness has deprived himself of the cure which repentance brings. Therefore, Paul rightly pronounced this to be more grievous than that. Therefore, just as not only those who do evil, but also those who praise and preach such, receive the same or even heavier punishment, so those who praise and

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preach good people become partakers of the crowns reserved for them. That this is so is evident from Scripture. For God thus speaks to Abraham: "I will bless those who bless you, and I will curse those who curse you" (Genesis 12:3). Anyone will see the same thing happen in the Olympic competitions. For it is not only the athlete who wears the crown, nor the one who has endured labor and sweat, but even he who praises the victor reaps no small pleasure from his praise. Therefore, I do not only declare that generous and magnanimous man blessed for his philosophy of mind, but you also for your kind spirit towards him. And he fought and conquered, and took the crown; but you, because you praised the victory, took no small part of the crown for yourselves. So that this pleasure may be more abundant for you, and the fruit more abundant, let us now also explain the remaining parts of this history to you. When the writer of the history had mentioned the words with which David condemned the murder, he added: "He did not allow them to rise up and kill Saul" (1 Samuel 24:8), wishing to demonstrate both their minds ready for murder and his fortitude. But many indeed who seem to be philosophizing, even if they themselves do not accept murder, nevertheless restrain others who are preparing for murder. But not David; he, just as if he had accepted something on his side for which he would have to give an account, not only did he not touch the enemy, but he also restrained others who wanted to kill him, becoming an excellent companion and a bodily guardian for his enemy. Therefore, it is not an aberration to say that David at that time fell into a more serious crisis than Saul himself. For he did not endure a light conflict or struggle while they tried in every way to rescue him from the ambushes which the soldiers were preparing for him; nor did he fear that he himself would be killed, but he feared that some of the soldiers, obeying their anger, would kill him; and for this reason, he invented an excuse of this kind. And they indeed accused, and Saul was accused while he was asleep, but he defended his enemies; but

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God was the judge and confirmed the sentence of David. For without the protection of God, he would not have been able to overcome those furious men; but there was the grace of God residing on the lips of the prophetess, which added a certain charm to her words. Although David also brought this no light moment here, who, since he had so instructed them in a previous time, therefore found them ready and deadly in the moment of the conflict. For he had led them not as a war leader over the soldiers, but as a priest, and that church was already in full swing.

Thus, as some bishop, having received the gift of a bishop, had a sermon for them, and after the sermon was over, he offered a sacrifice, and that a certain admirable and incredible thing, not by slaying a calf or by killing a lamb, but by what was much more honorable than these, offering meekness and humanity to God, and by slaying the irrational impulse of the mind, and by killing anger, and by mortifying the members which are upon the earth. And he himself became both a victim and a sacrifice and an altar (Colossians 3:5). For both the reason which offered meekness and humanity, and the humanity and meekness itself, and finally the heart in which these were offered, were all the same man.

2. After he had sacrificed this illustrious victim, then he brought back the victory and did not omit anything that pertained to the trophy. Saul finally got up from the matter of these conflicts and came out of the cave, unaware of all that had been done. And David came out after him (1 Samuel 24:9), looking at the sky with his free eyes, and then rejoicing more than when he had overthrown Goliath and cut off the barbarian's head. For this victory was more significant, these spoils more magnificent, this booty more illustrious, this trophy more glorious. For there he had need of slings and stones and swords; but here all prudence and reason were accomplished, and victory happened without arms, and a bloodless trophy was erected. And so he returned,

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not carrying the head of that barbarian, but with his mind's agitation calmed, and his anger enervated; nor did he lay these spoils in Jerusalem, but in heaven and in that heavenly city. Now the women did not come to meet him dancing, welcoming him with praises, but the people of angels applauded from on high, admiring his philosophy and humanity. For he ascended as an enemy wounded with innumerable wounds, as one who, although he had saved Saul, yet pierced that true enemy, the devil, with many wounds. For as we, fighting among ourselves through anger and clashing in mutual conflict, he now rejoices, now rejoices; so, while we have peace and concord, and moderate our anger, he is again contracted and cast down, namely the enemy of peace and the enemy of concord, and the father of envy. So David went out, carrying that right hand crowned together with his head, equal to the price of the whole world. For just as their Emperors, who have excelled in the boxing match, often crown the right hand of the boxer or the pancratist before his head, so God crowned that hand which could draw a pure sword and show the sword to God unstained by any blood, and finally withstand such a storm of wrath. Saul did not go out wearing a diadem, but he went out wearing a crown of justice; he did not go out wearing the purple robe of a king, but he went out clothed with humanity surpassing human nature, which is a robe more magnificent than any robe.

He came out of the cave with as much glory as the three boys came out of the burning furnace. For as the fire did not burn them, so he was not consumed by the conflagration of anger. And indeed nothing harmed them outside, in which they were engaged (Daniel 3:19-28); but here, although he had coals burning inside, while outside the devil was forcefully fanning the furnace, from the sight of the enemy, from the exhortation of the soldiers, from the ease of carrying out the deed, from the solitude of those who could help Saul, from the memory of past

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dangers, and from fear (for these things, and the branches, pitch, stubble, and all the rest with which that Babylonian furnace was kindled, excited a brighter flame), yet David was not inflamed, nor was he in any way affected in this way, as it was fitting for him to be; but he came out pure, and having looked upon the face of the enemy, he took on a most courageous and philosophical spirit. For when he saw him sleeping and remaining motionless and unable to do anything, he spoke with his mind: where is that madness now? where is that malice? where are all these tricks, all these snares? All these have gone, and the little sleep that has fallen upon him has perished; the king lies bound, since we have neither thought of nor accomplished any of these things. He saw the sleeping boy, and the philosopher was afraid of death common to all. For sleep is nothing else than temporary death and daily destruction. It is not untimely that anyone here also remembers Daniel. For just as he ascended from the pit after overcoming wild lions (Daniel 14:27-42), so he came out of the cave after overcoming other, far more savage beasts. For just as those lions were sitting here and there on this side of the just man, so this man was attacked by emotions more ferocious and powerful than all lions: on the one hand, indignation for the past, on the other, fear of the future; but he restrained both of these, closing the mouths of the beasts, teaching by his own actions that nothing is safer than sparing the enemy; on the other hand, nothing is more dangerous than wanting to take revenge and take vengeance. The other man, therefore, who had decided to invade, lay naked and unarmed, and deprived of all aids, no different from a prisoner delivered into the hands of the enemy; but this man, while he yielded and everywhere gave way, and while he did not even justly dare to attack, without machines, without arms, without cavalry, without soldiers, he took the enemy into his power; and what is the greatest of all, he made God more benevolent towards him.

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3. How much profit David made, having saved Saul. Much greater to spare than to lose. - For I do not declare that saint blessed because he saw the enemy lying under his feet, but because he spared him when he lay helpless before him. The one of which was the work of divine power, the other of his philosophy. How was it consistent that the soldiers afterwards observed him, how much benevolence they had felt towards him? For if they had had a thousand lives, would they not have readily sacrificed them for their leader, already from the reverence which he showed to the enemy, having in fact seen how benevolent he was towards his own? For he who was gentle and meek towards those by whom he was troubled will be much more likely to be benevolent towards those who were kind to him; which thing was certainly the greatest pledge of security for him. But they were not only more benevolent towards him, but also more ready against the enemy; because they knew that they had God as their champion, who was always present to the leader, looking forward to all his deeds. Therefore afterwards they obeyed David, not as a man, but as an angel. And so David, even before God rewarded him, even in this life received a greater reward and won a more illustrious victory by saving Saul than if he had slaughtered him. For what gain would he have made by killing an enemy, as much as he now gained by sparing him? Therefore weigh these things with yourself, when you have caught him completely injured, that it is much greater and more profitable to spare than to destroy. For he who kills an enemy will frequently condemn himself, carrying a bad conscience, while he is afflicted every day and every hour by that pressing sin; but he who spares, and in a short time conquers his passions, afterwards rejoices and delights, supported by the best hope, and expecting rewards for endurance from God. But if he ever falls into any evil, he will confidently demand a great reward from God, just as he also received great and wonderful rewards from God for the mercy shown to his enemy. But let us see what follows.

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David went out of the cave after Saul and cried after him, saying: "My Lord, my king." And Saul looked behind him, and bowing himself, David fell on his face to the ground and worshipped him (1 Samuel 24:9). These things bring no less adornment to David than the saved enemy. For he was not of a common mind, not to be puffed up by the benefits bestowed upon his neighbor, nor to be so affected as most of the common people are wont to be, who, like slaves, despise those whom they have helped with a blessing. But David was not so blessed, but rather appeared more modest after the benefits bestowed. The reason was that he did not take any credit for the excellent deeds he had done, but attributed them all to the divine gift. And therefore he who had saved, the same adored the saved, and again called him king, and himself a servant, because of his dignity restraining the swelling of his mind, and mitigating his anger, and removing his envy. Let us hear further the apology itself. Why do you hear the words of the people, saying, "Behold, David seeks your soul" (1 Samuel 24:10)? And yet he who wrote this history said before that the whole people were with David, and that he was pleasing in the eyes of the king's servants, and that the prince's son and the whole army stood by David in spirit (2 Samuel 18:16, 22, 28; 19:1). How then does he say that there were those who falsely accused him and provoked Saul against him? For that he had not been provoked by the impulse of others, but by his own mind, to wage war with the just, was declared by the one who wrote the volume, when he said that envy was born from the praises of David and then grew day by day (1 Samuel 18:9-29). For what reason, then, did he transfer the blame to others, saying: "Why do you hear the words of your people, saying, Behold, David seeks your life?" Surely, in order to give him an opportunity to shake off his malice. This is what parents often do to their children, when someone, rebuking their son for being corrupt and having done many evils, although he is convinced that he has fallen into perverted ways through his own

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malice, yet frequently casts the blame on others, saying thus: "I know that it was not your fault, but others have corrupted and seduced you: this is all their sin." For the son, hearing these things, will be able gradually to recover from his wickedness and more easily return to good fruit, while he is ashamed and blushes at seeming unworthy of this praise. Paul did the same when writing to the Galatians. After many long speeches and after the accusations with which he had accused them, which are not to be mentioned, at the end of the letter, wishing to remove the blame from them, so that they, having recovered a little from their crimes, may come to an excuse, he speaks in this manner: "I trust in you, that you will think nothing else: but he who troubles you, let him be judged, whoever he may be" (Galatians 5:10). David did the same here: for when he says, "Why do you hear the words of the people saying, Behold, David seeks your life?" he indicates that there are others who would provoke, others who would infect his mind, seeking by all means to give him an occasion for an excuse. Immediately, pleading his own case, he says: "Behold, your eyes have seen this day how the Lord delivered you into my hands in the cave, and that I would not kill you, but spared you, and said: I will not lay a hand on my lord, for he is the Lord's anointed" (1 Samuel 24:11). They indeed, he says, slander with words, but I in reality purge myself, and by my very deeds drive away the crime. I have no need of words, since the very outcome of the events can teach you more clearly than any speech who they are, by whom I, and how the slander and slander was brought against me. Of these things, I call no other, but yourself, as a witness, yourself, I say, who by my favor you have been preserved.

4. But how could Saul be a witness of these things, who was asleep when these things happened, and neither heard the words nor saw David present at the time, nor actually speaking with the soldiers? How

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then shall we proceed, so that a clear declaration may be made? For if he had summoned the spies, Saul would have suspected their testimony, and would have thought them to be speaking in favor of the just. But if he had attempted to excuse himself by reasonings and probable arguments, it would have been that he would have been less believed, since the judge's mind was already corrupted. For how could he who, having been affected by so many benefits, pursued a war without any merit, suspect that someone, having suffered an injury, would have spared him, having caught the one who had done the injury? For the common people often judge others from their own minds: for example, a person who is constantly intoxicated could not easily believe that a person lives soberly; a person who spends his time with harlots considers even those who live chastely to be incontinent; again, he who takes away other people's things will not be easily convinced that there are men who also deepen their own. Similarly, this man, once occupied with anger, would not have easily believed that this man was so far above his own feelings that he would not only not harm anything, but also save the one who tears. Since therefore both the mind of the judge was corrupt, and if the witnesses had been produced, they would have been under suspicion, by prudent counsel he found a certain proof that could shut the mouths of even the most shameless. What is this? The hem of the cloak, which he held out and said: "Behold the hem of your cloak in my hand, which I took away, and did not kill you" (1 Samuel 24:12). A mute witness indeed, but more evident to all who have a voice. For if I had not been, he says, close to you, I would not have stood close to you; I could not have cut off a part of your garment. Do you see how much good has arisen from the fact that David was initially moved? For if he had not been moved to anger, we would not have known the philosophy of man (for to most people he would have seemed to have spared it not from philosophy, but from amazement), nor would he have cut off a part of his cloak;

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which if he had not cut off, he could not have given credence to the enemy's other arguments. But now, since he was both moved and cut off, he has provided the most certain proof of his providence. Therefore, since he has presented such true and indubitable testimony, he immediately makes him an enemy and judge and witness of his reverence towards him, speaking in this way: "Know and see today that there is no iniquity in my hand, nor contempt for you, and you bind my soul, that you may take it" (Ibid.). One should admire his magnanimity, especially because he does not take excuse except from those things that had happened that day. For this he hints at when he says: "Know and see today." For I am not speaking of things that have happened before; this day is sufficient for me as a proof. Although he could have enumerated many and great benefits which he had previously conferred on him, if he had wished, he could have mentioned a singular conflict which he had undertaken with a barbarian, and said: "When a barbarian war, like a flood, was about to destroy the entire city, while you were terrified and trembling with fear and daily expecting death, I approached you without anyone compelling you, nay, I prevented you and held you back, saying: You cannot go, for you are a boy, but he is a warrior in his youth" (1 Samuel 17:33): I did not restrain myself, but I rushed forward alone for all, I overtook the enemy, cut off his head, and like a torrential onslaught, I repelled the assaults of those barbarians, and I established the tottering republic; and through me you indeed hold the kingdom and life, but all the others hold the city and houses, children and wives, in addition to their lives. And after that, he could mention the trophy again and other wars which he had fought bravely and successfully, this not inferior. To these, that when once and again, nay oftener, he had tried to take him out of the midst, and had twisted a spear at his head; yet he does not remember the evils; likewise that after those deeds, when Saul was obliged to pay the rewards of the former battle, he demanded a dowry,

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not gold, not silver, but slaughter and destruction; and David did not even refuse that. Nor could he say these things only, but much more and greater things than these; but he said nothing of these, nor did he have the heart to reproach him for his benefits, but only to persuade him that he was one of the number of those who both loved and worshipped him, not who plotted rebellion or intrigue.

Therefore, having passed over all these, he brought forward only what had happened that day in his defense. He was so pure and free from all vain glory, and looked to no one else but the will of God alone. Then he said: "The Lord judge between me and thee" (1 Samuel 24:13). He said this word not because he desired to punish Saul or to take punishment from him, but to instill fear in him from the remembrance of the judgment that was to come; nor to instill fear in him only, but to clear himself from the suspicion of crime. Indeed, he says, I have the chief proof from my own deeds; but if you do not believe, I call God himself as a witness, who knows the secrets of every mind and can search consciences.

5. But he spoke these things, declaring that he would never have dared to call upon that Judge, whom he could not impeach, and to bring upon himself condemnation, unless he had the utmost certainty that he was pure from all scheming. And that what we say is not conjecture, but that, wishing at the same time to purge himself and to call him back to sobriety, he made mention of that judgment, those things which had already been done sufficiently show; but those things which happened afterwards can no less confirm this fact. For when Saul again fell into his hands, after giving him so much safety and wishing to kill him, and since he could have destroyed the enemy with his entire army, he sent him away safe and sound. Therefore, knowing that the king's illness was incurable and that he would never set his mind on him as a hostile one, he removed himself from his sight and lived among the

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barbarians, serving, deprived of honor, suffused with shame, providing for himself with toil and misery the necessities of life. But it is not only this that we are surprised at, but also that after he had heard that the king had fallen in battle, he tore his clothes and sprinkled himself with ashes and mourned with that mourning with which one mourns the loss of one's firstborn and true son; then, calling out his name together with the name of his son, also composing encomiums and emitting voices of bitter grief, he remained unmoved until evening, cursing even the very places that had received Saul's blood. "Mountains," he says, "Gilboa, let neither dew nor rain fall on you: mountains of death, because there the tabernacles of the mighty were taken away" (2 Samuel 1:21). What fathers often do, so that they turn away from their homes and look with sorrow at the threshold through which they carried their son, he did this also, devoting those mountains which had received that slaughter. "I hate," he says, "even the place itself because of the dead who lie there." Therefore, do not be watered from now on with the heavenly rains, because you have been once badly watered with the blood of my friends; and he repeated those names from time to time, speaking thus: "Saul and Jonathan, lovely and handsome, were not used to being separated in their lives, nor were they separated in their deaths" (2 Samuel 1:21). For since their absence did not permit him to embrace their bodies, he embraced their names, soothing his pain in these ways as far as permitted and mitigating the magnitude of the calamity. For since the evil was thought by many to be incurable, he seized upon this very fact as an argument for consolation. For what he says, "They were not separated in their lives, nor were they separated in their deaths," were words of nothing other than that this should yield to the consolation of pain. For now, he says, it cannot be said that a son mourns that he is an orphan, nor that a father laments his bereavement; but what has happened to no one, he says, has happened to them: namely, that on the same day they were snatched from the living,

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neither surviving the other. For he thought that life would be unpleasant to him if one had been torn from the other. Are you now moved, are you now weeping, and are you troubled in mind; have your eyes changed to the point of shedding tears? Now let each one remember for me the enemy who has done him wrong, with pain still burning in his mind, and let him both keep him alive and mourn him when he is dead, not indeed for show, but from the heart and from the heart: even if some inconvenience must be endured, lest he offend him who has done him wrong, let him do all things at the same time and then suffer them, expecting great rewards from God. Behold, he also attained the kingdom, and yet he did not defile his hands with murder; but having a pure right hand, thus he was redeemed with a crown, thus he ascended to the throne, bearing a more magnificent encomium with purple and diadem, namely, that he had spared an enemy, which he had mourned with the same extinction. For this reason, he is celebrated not only while alive, but also while dead in the memory of men. Wherefore, if you desire to attain perpetual glory here, and there to enjoy solid goods, imitate the virtue of this just man, emulate his philosophy, and show by your deeds the endurance of these injuries, so that by enduring the same labors you may obtain the same goods: which may it be that we all may attain, by the grace and kindness of our Lord Jesus Christ, to whom with the Father and the Holy Spirit be glory, dominion, and honor, now and ever, and unto the ages of ages. Amen.

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That it is dangerous to attend spectacles, and that it makes perfect adulterers, and hence sadness and contention arise; also that David surpassed all kinds of tolerance in what he did towards Saul; finally, that to bear robbery with equanimity is no less a virtue than to bestow alms.

1. Indeed, I believe that many of those who had recently deserted us and gone to the spectacles of iniquity are present today. But I would like to know those who are openly here, so that I may keep them from the sacred vestibules, not so that they may perpetually wander abroad, but so that they may return corrected: since fathers also frequently demand their delinquent sons from their houses and remove them from the table, not so that they may always be free from sin, but so that, having been made better by this correction, they may return to their paternal lot with due praise and honor. Shepherds also do the same when they separate sheep afflicted with scabies from the healthy ones, so that, having been cured of their miserable disease, they may safely return to the healthy ones again, lest the sick fill the whole flock with their disease. Therefore, we desired to know these; but although we cannot recognize them with the eyes of the body, yet the Word will recognize them completely, and their conscience, having been corrected, will easily persuade them to leave of their own accord and willingly, teaching that he alone is within who has a mind worthy of this exercise: as if, on the contrary, he who, living corruptly, participates in this sacred congregation, even if he is present here in body, is rejected, and indeed removed, more truly than those who have been excluded outside, to whom it is not yet permitted to participate in the sacred month. Indeed, those who have been expelled according to divine laws and remain outside are still in good hope: for if they only wish to correct their offenses, for which they were expelled by the

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Church, they will be able to return again with a pure conscience. But those who have condemned themselves, and who, having been warned not to enter until they have purged the stain contracted from their crimes, then behave shamelessly, render the wound and ulcer of the soul more bitter and greater. For it is not so grave to sin as to behave shamelessly after the sin, nor to obey the priests who command such things. And what, they say, have these committed so great a crime that they should be kept away from these sacred gates? Nay, what crime do you seek more grievous than this of those who, having defiled themselves with adultery, shamelessly and like rabid dogs, rush to the sacred table? But if you would know the manner of adultery, I will not tell you my words, but those of him who is to judge the whole life of a man: For he who sees a woman to lust after her has already committed adultery with her in his heart (Matthew 5:28). But if a woman happens to meet you in the marketplace, and is often neglected and often catches you looking at her more curiously by the very look of her face; those who, not simply, nor for fear, but with such zeal, and with such zeal that they even despise the Church, go on this errand, and yet, dwelling there all day long, their eyes fixed on the faces of those abject women, how can they deny that they have not seen them for lust? Where are also added broken and lascivious words, where are cautions of whoredom, where are voices vehemently composed for pleasure, where are eyes painted with antimony, where are cheeks dyed with colors, where are clothes more elaborately arranged, where is the whole body's posture full of make-up, and many other flatteries designed to deceive and ensnare those who look on; where is the sloth of the spectators, and much confusion, hence the very place inviting to lasciviousness, both from those acrobats which preceded and from those which followed? There are added irritations through the pipes and tubes, and other modulations of its kind, tempting into fraud, softening the strength of the mind, and preparing the minds of those

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who sit there for the snares and delight of harlots, and making them more easily taken. For if here, where there are psalms, where there are sermons, where there is the exposition of divine oracles, where there is the fear of God, and much piety, lust frequently sneaks in secretly, like some cunning thief: how can those who sit in the theater, who hear and see nothing healthy, but are filled with much filth and wickedness, who suffer siege on all sides, through their ears and eyes, be able to overcome evil lust? Again, if they cannot, how can they ever be absolved from the crime of adultery? Then how can those who are not free from the crime of adultery approach these sacred vestibules without repentance and be partakers of this illustrious assembly?

2. Wherefore I exhort and beseech them, that they first, by confession and penance and all other remedies, purge themselves of the sin contracted from theatrical spectacles, and so hear divine discourses. For we do not sin in the least; which is plainly evident to everyone from examples. For if a servant were to place a servile tunic full of filth and many lice in a chest, where the precious garments of the masters and gold are kept, tell me, would you bear that insult with equanimity? But what if someone were to pour dung and soot into a golden vessel, in which ointments are always kept, would you not inflict blows on the one who committed this crime? Shall we then be solicited with such care for chests and vessels, garments and ointments, and shall we think that our own souls are worth less than all these, and shall we set up devilish pomps there where the ointment of the Spirit is infused? There are the fables of Satan, there are the songs of whoredom full of filth? Tell me, with what mind will God bear these things? But there is not so much difference between anointing and cleanness, between the garments of a hermit and a servile one, as there is between the grace of the Spirit and this perverse action. Do you not notice, O man, with what eyes you look at the bed in the orchestra, where the detestable

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fabrics of adultery are being performed, with the same eyes you look at the sacred table, where the terrible mysteries are being performed? while with the same ears you hear both the harlot speaking obscenely and the prophet and apostle introducing the mysteries of Scripture? while with the same heart you take lethal poisons and this holy and terrible victim? Are not these the subversion of life, the corruption of marriages, wars and fights and quarrels in homes? For when you return home, having become more dissolute, more soft, more lascivious, and an enemy of all modesty, after those spectacles, the sight of your wife will be less delightful, whatever she may be. Indeed, inflamed by that lust which you have drunk in the theaters, and captivated by that strange spectacle which has driven you mad, you despise your chaste and modest wife and companion of your whole life, you inflict insults upon her, and you commit countless disgraceful acts, not because you have anything to blame her for, but because you are ashamed to confess your illness, because you are ashamed to show the wound with which you returned home wounded in the spectacles, you weave other causations, seeking unjust occasions for enmity, detesting everything that is at home, and yearning for that wicked and impure lust from which you received the wound, and while you carry the sound of the voice remaining in your mind, as well as the looks, movements, and all those images of whorish lust, you look with pleasure at nothing that is at home. And what am I talking about a wife or a family, when you will later see even the church itself less willingly, and will listen with weariness to a discourse on chastity and modesty? For what is said to you is no longer for doctrine, but for accusation, and will gradually lead you into despair: at last you will break away from the discipline used for the public benefit of all. Wherefore I beg you all, that you yourselves also avoid wicked sojourns in spectacles, and that you withdraw others who have been led away from them. For whatever is done there is not enjoyment; but destruction, but punishment, and

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punishment. What profit is that temporary pleasure, while perpetual pain arises from it, and while, stimulated by concupiscence both night and day, you are troublesome and hated by all? Therefore, shake yourself, considering what you will become when you return from church, and what you will become when you return from the spectacles, and comparing these days with them: if you do this, there will be no need for our discourse. For it would be sufficient to compare this day with that, to show both how great is the benefit on the one hand, and how great is the harm on the other. I have never thought that this should be said to your charity, and I will never cease to say it. Thus we will admonish those who are subject to this disease, and we will confirm those who are healthy: for this speech will be useful to both: to the one indeed that they may desist, but to the other not to fall into it. But since it is necessary that the rebuke be moderate, here we will put an end to the admonition, and what remains of the above argument we shall resolve, returning to David. For here it is the custom of painters, whenever they wish to complete some image expressed to life, to sit one, two, or three days with those whom they depict, so that by assiduous contemplation they may express a likeness without error and exactly formed. Therefore, since it is our purpose to depict for you today not the image of bodily form, but the beauty of the soul and spiritual beauty, we want David himself to be present with you, so that all of you, looking at him, may recall to your mind the expressed beauty of the just man, his sweetness, his magnanimity, in short, all his virtue. For if images of the body bring some comfort to those who look at them, images of the mind will do the same much more. And indeed, it is not permissible to look at them everywhere, but you must stand still in one place: this, however, nothing prevents you from carrying it around with you wherever you wish. For after you have placed it in the recesses of your mind, wherever you may be, you will be able to contemplate it often and derive great benefit from it. And just as those

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who suffer from eye trouble, if they frequently look at it while holding sponges and blue-colored cloths, from its color they receive some relief from their disease: in the same way, if you have the image of David before your eyes, and constantly fix your eyes on him, even if the mind's anger disturbs your eye a thousand times, looking to this model of virtue, you will attain perfect health and a pure philosophy of mind.

3. No enemy is worse than Saul. - Let no one therefore say to me: I have an enemy who is wicked, corrupt, incorrigible. Whatever you may say, he is not worse than Saul, who, once and again, nay more often, saved by David, when he himself had laid a thousand plots against him, yet for so many benefits received, he persevered in his wickedness. What then have you to accuse your enemy of? That he has taken away part of the land, that he has done wrong in the fields, that he has transgressed the boundaries of the house, that he has taken away your slaves, that he has brought violence, that he has occupied yours without right, that he has reduced you to poverty? But he has not yet taken life, which Saul attempted: but if he did attempt to take life, perhaps he dared to do so once, not once, twice, or thrice, or more often, as Saul did: but if he had also once, if twice, if thrice, if more often attempted this, yet not with so many favors from you, but not when he had once and again fallen into your hands and been saved: and if this also was done, so also David himself again overcomes. For it is not equal to live under the old law, and now after the grace of the Gospel to forgive such things freely. David had not heard the parable of the ten thousand talents and of the hundred denarii; he had not heard the prayer saying, Forgive men their debts, as your heavenly Father also doth (Mark 11:25): he had not seen Christ crucified, nor shed his precious blood, nor had he heard innumerable discourses about this philosophy; he had not been a partaker of such a sacrifice, nor of the

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blood of the Lord, but was brought up by more imperfect laws, and did not require anything of the kind, yet he reached the pinnacle of evangelical philosophy. But you, often angry, retain the memory of injuries: but here, when he feared for the future, knowing for certain that if he kept the enemy, he would be exiled from both the city and the city, and would lead a calamitous life, he did not cease to care for him, but did everything, thus fostering such an enemy against him. Who can mention greater tolerance than this? Moreover, that you may learn not only from the past, but also from what is happening now, that it is possible to return to favor with any man who harbors a hostile spirit towards you, what is more savage than a lion? And yet men, by art overcoming nature, render this lion gentle and docile: and the most monstrous and proud of all beasts becomes gentler than any sheep, so that he walks through the forum, terrifying no one. What excuse, then, shall we have, what pardon shall we obtain, if, when we conquer wild beasts, we deny that men can ever be appeased and made kind to us? But it is indeed against the nature of beasts to be gentle, but it is against the nature of man to be savage. Therefore, when we conquer nature in them, with what head shall we excuse ourselves, if we cause the mind's purpose to be uncorrectable in man? But if you still contend, I would say this: although a man is sick with an incurable disease, the more labor there is, the greater will be your reward; if you persevere, treating one suffering from an incurable disease.

Let us therefore consider this one thing, not that we should suffer any evil from our enemies, but that we should do no evil to them: so let us suffer no evil, even if we endure innumerable evils: just as David, when he was cast out, when he was carried into exile, when he was pursued by snares to the point of endangering his life, did not suffer any bitter thing: but rather, by his enemy he became more illustrious and honorable, and more lovable to all others, and that not only to men,

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but to God himself. For what harm did that holy man suffer, when so many things were suffered by Saul? Is he not to this day sung of as illustrious on earth, more illustrious in heaven? Do not indescribable goods and the kingdom of heaven remain to him? Again, what good did that unhappy and wretched man gain, having devised so many snares? Was he not cast out of the kingdom? Is it not to be pitied that he perished with his son, and is blamed by all (1 Samuel 31:6), and what is more grievous than these, that he suffers eternal punishment? Finally, what is it that you accuse, why do you not want to return to favor with him? Did he take away money? But if you endure the robbery with great severity, you will receive as much reward as if you had deposited it with the poor. For both he who gave to the needy and he who usurped another's property neither prepares a trap nor prays badly; both do it for the sake of God. Therefore, since the reason for the expense is the same, it is clear that there would be one and the same crown for both. But he laid a trap for his life and attempted to kill him? That thing will be imputed to you as martyrdom if you are counted among those who have well deserved it, and who have provoked such hostility, and who have not ceased to pray for him, beseeching God that he may be merciful to him.

4. Let us not, therefore, think that God forbade David from being killed by Saul: but consider that he was redeemed from the traps of Saul by a triple and quadruple crown of martyrdom. For he who for God's sake saved his enemy, he who once, twice, nay frequently had waved a spear at his head, when he had obtained the power to kill, yet spared him, when he thought afterwards that he would be impelled by him again: it is clear that he was killed a thousand times by the ruler of his soul; but being killed a thousand times for God's sake, he received many crowns of martyrdom: who, as Paul also says, I die daily for God's sake (1 Corinthians 15:31), he also suffered the same for God's

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sake. For when he could have removed the enemy who was plotting against him from his midst, he did not want to for God's sake, and preferred to be in danger daily, rather than to be delivered from so many deaths by the right of faith. But if it is not lawful to avenge and hate the plotter to the point of endangering his own life, much less is it lawful to avenge the one who has vulgarly injured him.

To be afflicted with reproaches by enemies, or to be brought into suspicion, seems more intolerable than all deaths. Come, therefore, let us consider this. Has anyone cursed you, called you an adulterer and a heretic? If he says this truly, correct him: if falsely, mock him; if you are conscious of the things that are being accused of, repent; if not, despise him: nay, rather, not only do not mock and neglect him, but also rejoice and exult according to the word of the Lord, who commands us to do so. When, he says, they shall revile you, and shall say every evil word against you falsely, rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven (Matthew 5:11-12). And again, Rejoice and be glad, when they shall cast out your name as evil lyingly (Luke 6:22-25). But if the accuser speaks the truth, and you bear his words with modesty, not reviling him, nor rebuking him, but groaning bitterly, condemning your faults, you will receive a lesser reward than the former. And I will try to prove this to you from the Scriptures, so that you may know that friends do not bring as much benefit when they praise and speak to your credit as enemies do by criticizing you, even if they have spoken the truth, yet so that we may use their accusations for what they should. For friends often flatter you to gain credit; they bring your faults to the fore against your enemies. For since we do not see our sins because of the love we have for them, they, because they see them better than we do because of hatred, drive us by reproach to the necessity of correction: so that their enmity may yield to us for the greatest benefit, not only because we understand our errors when

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admonished by them, but also because we lay them aside. For if an enemy reproaches you for a sin of which you are aware, and you, hearing it, do not reproach him in return, but with a bitter groan implore God, you have immediately laid aside all guilt. I ask what could be more pleasing? What is easier for the abolition of crimes? But lest we seem to excite with human words, we will bring forth testimony on this matter from the divine Scriptures, so that you may not doubt anything further. There was a Pharisee and a publican, of whom the latter had indeed advanced to the utmost wickedness, the one practiced the utmost righteousness, as one who spent his means and fasted constantly, pure from robbery: on the contrary, the other had spent all his life in robbery and violence. Both went up into the temple to pray. He stood and said: I thank you, Lord, that I am not as other men, extortioners, covetous, nor even as this publican (Luke 18:11-12). But the publican, standing at a distance, did not rebuke the insult, nor did he rebuke me in return, nor utter those vulgar words: "Do you dare to mention my life and criticize my deeds? Am I not better than you? I will bear witness to your sins, and I will make sure that you never enter these sacred courts." The publican, I say, spoke none of those cold words of the kind that we use every day, showering each other with insults; but sighing bitterly and beating his breast, he said only this, "Be merciful to me, a sinner" (Luke 18:13), and he went down justified.

Do you see the speed? He received reproach and washed away reproach; he acknowledged sins and laid aside sins: and the accusation of crimes became for him the remission of crimes, and the enemy became a benefactor without knowing it. How many labors were there in undergoing the tax collector, in fasting, in sleeping on the ground, in watching, in distributing his goods to the poor, in sitting for a long time in sackcloth and ashes, that he might lay aside his sins so unavenged?

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But now, when he did nothing of the kind, he laid aside all iniquity with a simple word: and the reproaches and scoldings of the Pharisee, who seemed to be treating him with contempt, bore to him the crown of righteousness, and that without sweat, without labor, and without long delay. Do you see that we, even if someone were to preach to us truthfully, of which we ourselves are conscious, would not reciprocate these preachings with curses, but with bitter groans, imploring God for our sins, could lay aside all sins? In this way he too was justified: for since the Pharisee did not avenge himself on the insults, but groaned over his sins, he went down justified before him.

5. Do you see how much benefit the reproach of enemies brings, if we only cover it with philosophy in our minds? But if both those who lie and those who speak the truth benefit us, why do we grieve? Why do we burn? If you do not harm yourself, O man, neither friend nor enemy, not even the devil himself can harm you. For when those who afflict us with insults, who betray us, who plot against us to the point of endangering our very lives, bring us benefit, and some, as we have shown, crown us with martyrdom, while others, while reproaching us for our sins, make us righteous, as happened with the publican, why do we become angry and enraged against them? Let us not say, therefore, that he has provoked me terribly, that he has driven me to utter indecent words: we are everywhere the cause of such things. For if we wish to philosophize, not even a demon will be able to incite us to anger: and this is clear from many profound things, as well as from this very story of David which is now in our hands, which it would be worth while to bring into the open today, if we had first reminded your charity, where we recently ended the sermon. Where then did we end it? In the apology of David. Therefore it is necessary that we relate to you today the words of Saul, in order to see what he answered here to his most just apology. For not only from the words which David spoke,

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but also from Saul's speech, will we perceive the virtue of David: for if Saul answered anything calmly and meekly, we will impute the cause of it to David, who changed the man, who educated him, and who composed his mind to sobriety. What then did Saul say? After he had heard David speak, Behold the skirt of thy robe in my hand (1 Samuel 24:13), and all that he had brought in excuse: He said, This is thy voice, my son David (1 Samuel 24:17)? How suddenly the change took place! He who had never endured calling him even by his simple name, having even that appellation hated, now adopted him into kinship, calling him his son. What then was more fortunate for David, who made a father out of a murderer, a sheep out of a wolf, who filled the furnace of wrath with much dew, who turned the storm into calm, who quenched all the swelling of the anger of a burning mind? For the word of David, entering into the mind of that fierce man, accomplished this whole change, which you may perceive from the words of Saul. For he did not say, These are thy words, my son David? but, This is thy voice, my son David? and soon he became heated up at the very voice. And just as a father, having heard the voice of his son returning after a long interval, is excited not only at the sight of him, but also at the very voice: so Saul, at the same time as David's words entered his mind, cast off his enmity, and now he recognized the saint, having laid aside his affection, received his affection. For having laid aside his anger, he received tranquility and compassion. And just as as long as night is present, we often do not even recognize a friend who is present, but soon the day has broken, we recognize his sight even from a distance: in the same way enmity is wont to become accustomed. As long as we carry a malevolent spirit among ourselves, the voice heard sounds differently to us, and we look at the very face with a corrupted mind: but when we have laid aside our anger, the voice which was before hated and hostile seems to us peaceful and most pleasant, and the very sight which was before hostile and unpleasant then becomes lovable

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and pleasant.

6. When anger is released, we clearly recognize what was not apparent to us when anger was boiling. The most powerful voice of David. - The same happens in a storm. The gathering of clouds does not allow the beauty of the sky to be visible to us; but although we have the most discerning eyes, we can never reach that heavenly delight. But when the heat of the rays, having broken through and scattered the clouds, shows the sun, it again shows the beauty of the sky. The same happens in us when anger is boiling, while resentment stands like a dense cloud before the eyes and ears, causing words and sights to appear otherwise than they are. But as soon as someone has philosophized, he has put down hatred, and has scattered the cloud of illness, then finally, with an uncorrupted mind, he will do what he can to extinguish all that bitterness, which does not obscure all who have ever earned a bright name for the doctrine of philosophy?

Nothing is more powerful than kindness. It is in our power to calm anger. - And you, therefore, if an enemy ever falls into your hands, do not look to how you can avenge him, and send him away sprinkled with countless insults, but how you can heal him, how you can bring him back to sobriety: and do not cease to do and say everything until you have overcome his cruelty by your gentleness. For nothing is more powerful than kindness. Which someone has declared, saying: A soft word will break the bones (Proverbs 25:15). But what is harder than a bone? And yet if someone is equally hard and rigid and broken, he will easily overcome him who treats him gently. And again, A gentle answer turns away anger (Proverbs 15:1). Whence it is clear that it is more in your power to anger or to reconcile the enemy than in his. For it is not in those who are moved with anger, but in the ignorant, that either their anger is extinguished or the fire is kindled anew. And this also he who said the former has made clear by a simple example. For

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as, he says, if you blow into a fire-pan, you kindle the fire: on the contrary, if you spit, you extinguish it, and both are in your hand (Sirach 28:14): so also in enmity against your neighbor, if you utter puffed up and foolish words, you stir up his fire, and kindle coals: but if you bring forth gentle and moderate words, before it flares up, you will extinguish all anger. Do not say, therefore, I have suffered these things, or I have heard these things, when all these things are in your power. For in this way anger, like a spark, can either extinguish or kindle, and either excite or calm fury. When you see your enemy, or if it comes to mind how much you have heard and suffered, make sure you forget all of these; even if you remember, you will still attack the devil. But gather together if he has ever said or done anything humanely. If you dwell on these things, you will more quickly dissolve enmity. But if there is a desire to accuse him, and to demand from him: first cast away the emotion of the mind, and extinguish the anger, and then demand with him, then rebuke, and you will easily be able to overcome. For when we are moved with anger, we cannot say or hear anything healthy at all: but free from disturbance, we will never utter a harsh word ourselves, nor will we hear others speaking harshly in the same way. Nor is it the very nature of what is said, and a mind occupied with hatred, that is wont to exasperate us. For it frequently happens that when we hear the same insults, whether from friends joking or playing jokes, or from little children, not only do we not feel any annoyance, nor are we exasperated, but we even laugh and are delighted, because we do not hear them with a corrupt affection of mind, nor with a mind preoccupied with anger. In the same way, if you extinguish your anger, if you cast out your hatred, nothing that is said will be able to offend you.

8. He who does wrong is more worthy of tears. But what am I saying about words? Let not even deeds offend, just as he did not offend the

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blessed one with any of these; but when he saw the enemy armed against his safety, and leaving nothing untried for his sake, not only was he not exasperated, but rather he grieved for his evils: the more vehemently he schemed, the more intensely he wept for him. For he knew, I say, he knew for certain, that not he who suffers wrong, but he who does it, is worthy of tears and lamentations, as he who injures himself. Therefore he used a long excuse with him, and did not stop before he had moved the enemy to an excuse with tears and lamentations. For after he had wept and uttered a bitter voice, after he had cried out loudly, hear what he has to say. You are more just than I, since you have rewarded me good, but I have rewarded you evil (1 Samuel 24:18). Do you see how he condemns his own wickedness, and preaches the virtue of justice, and purifies him without any compulsion? Do the same, quickly. When an enemy falls into your hands, do not accuse him, but purge him, that you may drive him to his own condemnation. For if we accuse us, he is exasperated: if we excuse us, he, respecting our humanity, will soon condemn himself. In this way, at the same time, refutation is made without suspicion, and he puts off all malice. Which also happens here: when he who was affected by injury is silent, he who had done many things accuses himself with vehemence. For he did not simply say, You have done me good, but, You have repaid me good: that is, For the ambushes, for the murder, for those countless evils, You have repaid me great benefits. But I have not become better in this way, but after those good deeds of yours I have persisted in my wickedness: I believe that you have not changed in this way, but you have consistently maintained your custom, continuing us who were again plotting against you with benefits. In these individual words, how many crowns did David appear worthy? For although Saul's mouth sounded these words, yet David's wisdom and art had implanted them in his mind. You have declared to me today the good you have done for me, since the Lord

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has this day delivered me into your hands, and you will not kill me (1 Samuel 24:19). Here again he gave testimony of his other virtue, namely, that, having deserved it, he did not remain silent, nor did he wash it away, but approached and told it; not indeed for show, but desiring to teach him by his very deeds that he was of the number of those who wished the king well and looked after his interests, not of those who would plot against him. For then it is right to mention one's own benefits, when a notable advantage is hoped from this. For whenever a man, without any given occasion, boasts and proclaims his own merits towards another, he is no better than a reproacher; but whenever he does so as to turn one who is ill-disposed and has a bad opinion of him to a different course, he is both a healer and a benefactor: which indeed David did, not seeking glory from Saul, but seeking to uproot the anger rooted in him. And therefore Saul praised him, because he was both well-deserved and had mentioned his merits.

Then our rewards remain most certain with God when they are denied by men. Then, when Saul, desiring to return the favor, could find no equal, he made God himself his debtor, speaking thus: If a man find his enemy in trouble, and let him go in a good way, and the Lord reward him well, as thou hast done to me this day (1 Samuel 24:20). For what could Saul return worthy of his merits, even if he had given him the kingdom with all the towns? For David had not only given him the towns and the kingdom, but also his life itself: but he had no other life to repay: and for this reason he relegates him to God, and honors him by giving him the rewards: and praising him, and instructing all, then greater rewards are reserved for us with God, when we receive diverse things for the countless benefits bestowed upon the enemy. After this he said: Behold I know that thou shalt reign, and that the kingdom of Israel shall be established in thine hand: and now swear unto me by the Lord, that thou wilt not cut off my seed after me, nor blot out my name

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out of the house of my father (1 Samuel 24:21-22). But I beseech thee, whence knowest thou this? In thine hand are the armies, in thine hand are the money, arms, cities, horses, soldiers, in short the whole force of the royal equipment: here, on the contrary, is deserted and naked, having neither city, nor house, nor family. Whence then, I pray thee, dost thou speak these things? Surely from the very manners of David. For naked and unarmed and deserted, could not have overcome me armed, and surrounded with so much power, unless he had God to help him; but he that hath God to help him is mightier than all. Seest thou to what a great philosophy Saul was led after the ambush? Do you see how it can be done that an enemy will spit out all malice and, changed, will return to better things?

9. Let us not, therefore, despair of our salvation. Since, if we have been led to the very depths of wickedness, let us recall ourselves from there and lay aside all wickedness.

What does he say next? Swear to me by God that you will not destroy my seed after you, nor will you destroy my name from my father's house (1 Samuel 24:21-22). The king asks a private matter: he who is crowned with a diadem acts as a suppliant, he implores an exile for his sons. And this very thing proves the virtue of David, that the enemy dared to ask this of the enemy. For in demanding an oath, he does not do so because he distrusts David's character, but because he considers how many evils he has done him. Swear to me that you will not destroy my seed after me. He leaves the enemy as a guardian to his sons, and his own offspring as his deputy, while with these words, seizing the hands of his sons and David, he introduces God as a hostage. What then is David? Did he use even a slight dissimulation and irony for this? Not at all: but he immediately nodded, and granted what was asked: and when Saul was dead, he not only did not kill his descendants, but then performed more than he had promised. For he

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brought his son, who was lame and weak in his legs (2 Samuel 9:13), into his own house, and made him a partaker of his own table, deserving him of the greatest honor, and neither blushed nor hid it, nor thought that the royal table was dishonored by the boy's lameness, but rather was adorned and made more luxurious. For as many as sat with him, they went away having acquired a great philosophical doctrine. For when they saw that Saul's son, who had done so many evils against David, was so dishonored in his presence, even though they had been more ruthless than all the wild beasts, they returned with shame and blush to their favor with all their enemies. Although if he himself had also ordered food to be given to him from another place, and had prescribed a certain manner of eating, it would have been very great: but to receive him at his own table is an extraordinary example of philosophy. You know for sure that it is not easy to love the sons of your enemies. What did I say to love? Not to hate, not to persecute, is great. Therefore, many, after the death of their enemies, poured out on their children the anger they had against them. But this most generous and magnanimous man was not only generous, but he also observed his living enemy, and after his death, he showed his children the kindness he had shown him. What was more sacred than that table, which was surrounded by the sons of the enemy, the enemy, I say, who had tried to kill him? What was more spiritual than that banquet, in which so many blessings abounded? It was rather the angels than the man who convened it. For to embrace and love the sons of the enemy, and to love the son of the one who had so often tried to take him out of the midst, and who had passed away while attempting to do so, he made it so that the choir would be referred to that one. Do this also, most esteemed one, by fostering the children of the living and the dead: of the living indeed, in this way you will win their parents to you; but by caring for the children of the deceased, that you may be adorned with much favor from God and many crowns, and that you may obtain

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countless prayers and prayers from all, not only from those who have been helped by your benefits, but also from those who have seen. Therefore, on that day, you will stand up for yourself, and great will be your patrons in the time of judgment, enemies helped by your benefits: you will expiate many sins, and reclaim your due. Even if you have committed countless sins, if you utter the prayer which says: Forgive your enemies, and your Father will forgive you your sins (Matthew 6:14): you will obtain many things with confidence, and in the meantime you will live good lives with hope, having everyone lovingly affected towards you. When they see you love your enemies and the children of your enemies in such a way that they will not be affected to become your friends and devotees, and do and suffer everything for your sake? Moreover, since you have such equal favor with God, since you have all people praying for you all good things, how much trouble will you feel, or who can live a happier life than you? Let us not only praise these in this life, but also, having gone forth, let us keep them, and, walking around, let us reconcile them to us, and make sincere friends out of enemies. But if there is also need of an apology, and forgiveness is to be sought from them, let us not refuse, even if we ourselves have been wronged. By this agreement, we will have more abundant rewards, by this agreement greater confidence, by this agreement we will undoubtedly pursue the kingdom of heaven, through the grace and goodness of our Lord Jesus Christ, with whom to the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit be glory, empire, and honor now and ever, and forever and ever. Amen.